

Judge halts federal job cuts

By Kevin Rector

SAN FRANCISCO — A federal judge blocked the Trump administration Wednesday from firing thousands of government workers based on the ongoing federal shutdown, granting a request from employee unions in California.

U.S. District Judge Susan Illston issued the temporary restraining order after concluding that the unions “will demonstrate ultimately that what’s being done here is both illegal and is in excess of authority and is arbitrary and capricious.” Illston slammed the Trump administration for failing to provide her with clear information about what cuts are actually occurring, for repeatedly changing its description and estimates of job cuts in filings before the court, and for failing — including during Wednesday’s hearing in San Francisco — to articulate an argument for why such cuts are not in violation of federal law.

“The evidence suggests that the Office of Management and Budget, OMB, and the Office of Personnel Management, OPM, have taken advantage of the lapse in government spending and government functioning to assume that all bets are off, that the laws don’t apply to them anymore,” Illston said — which she said was not the case.

She said the government justified providing inaccurate figures for the number of jobs being eliminated under its “reduction in force” orders by calling it a “fluid situation” — which she did not find convincing.

“What it is is a situation where things are being done before they are being thought through. It’s very much ready, fire, aim on [See Job cuts, A7]

Delay on word of COLA increase

Government shutdown pushes back Social Security’s cost-of-living announcement. **NATION, A6**



Photographs by MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

WADE CROWFOOT, top, records video during an aerial tour. Above, a fire crew walks in the Santa Monica Mountains in Topanga during a risk reduction project.

Controversial plan aims to reduce future wildfire risk

Animals and machines are part of prevention effort

By Noah Haggerty

Nine months after one of the worst fires the region has seen in recorded history, some parts of the Santa Monica Mountains are covered in thick, green and shrubby native chaparral plants; others are blackened, mostly fire-stricken earth where chaparral used to thrive; and still others are blanketed by bone-dry golden grasses where the land had years ago been choked out by fire.

Amid this tapestry is a scattering of homes and businesses with only a handful of roads snaking out: Topanga. The dangers, should a fire roar down the canyon, were painfully clear at a thousand feet to public officials viewing the area from a helicopter last week.

“If there are any issues on the boulevard...” County Supervisor Lindsey Horvath said into her headset, trailing off.

“The community is trapped,” said Wade Crowfoot, California secretary for

natural resources, finishing the thought.

Over the same mountains where the Palisades fire roared, the state is working on a nearly 675-acre flagship project to stop the next firestorm in the Santa Monica Mountains from devouring homes and killing residents.

Crews from the Los Angeles County Fire Department and the Mountains Recreation and Conservation Authority, a local land management agency, were [See Prevention, A14]

Justices signal weakening of the Voting Rights Act

If high court rejects race in redistricting, it would bolster GOP in next year’s midterms.

By David G. Savage

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court may help the GOP keep control of the House of Representatives next year by clearing the way for Republican-led states to redraw election districts now held by Black Democrats.

That prospect formed the backdrop on Wednesday as the justices debated the future of the Voting Rights Act in a case from Louisiana.

The court’s six conservatives, all Republican appointees, sounded ready to rein in the historic civil rights measure on the grounds that it forces Southern states to draw some election districts along racial lines.

That’s because “racially polarized” voting is still the norm there, said Janai Nelson, president of the NAACP Legal Defense Fund. “No Black person has ever been elected statewide in Louisiana,” she told the court.

Now, the state’s Republican leaders “seek a staggering reversal of precedent that would throw maps across the country into cha-

os,” she said.

Only the court’s three liberals appeared to agree.

At issue before the court is a second Black-majority district in Louisiana, but the outcome could have a significant political impact in Washington. Next year’s midterm elections will determine whether Democrats can retake control of the House.

A broad ruling that rejects the use of race in redistricting could cast doubt on the congressional districts now held by Black Democrats in solidly Republican states.

This will not “lead to there being no Black representation in Congress,” a Trump administration lawyer assured the court. There are “only 15 majority-Black districts” that may be threatened, he said.

Several justices on the right said that state lawmakers are entitled to draw districts with an eye to “partisan advantage.”

Last month, the Trump administration’s top courtroom attorney urged the justices to rule that partisan politics, not racial fairness, should guide the drawing of election districts for Congress and state legislatures.

“This court held that race-based affirmative action in higher education must come to an end,” Solicit- [See Justices, A7]

L.A. County calls state of emergency over ICE sweeps

By Summer Lin and Ruben Vives

The Los Angeles County Board of Supervisors this week approved a state of emergency that could benefit tenants and others hurt by the Trump administration’s immigration crackdown.

The action Tuesday is one of the most sweeping efforts by local authorities to push back at raids that have targeted several major American cities since the summer and comes amid weeks of clashes among immigration officers, protesters and others on the streets of Chicago.

The proclamation enables local agencies to expedite hiring to fill government positions needed to assist tenants and sets the stage for a future eviction moratorium for households that have lost income because of the raids.

In June, Los Angeles County became the first area under the current Trump administration to see widespread immigration

raids in public, which netted thousands of people, and local officials say they are using those experiences to craft protections.

The raids have prompted some to go underground out of fear of being arrested.

A study from UC Merced calculated that the mass deportation of California’s undocumented residents — who make up an estimated 8% of California’s workforce — would create a \$275-billion hole in the state’s economy.

The proclamation, introduced by Supervisors Lindsey Horvath and Janice Hahn, allows the county to coordinate interagency response and request state and federal assistance to help affected communities, according to a news release from Horvath.

“What’s happening in our communities is an emergency — and Los Angeles County is treating it like one,” Horvath said. “Declaring a Local Emergency ensures that the full weight of County government is aligned to support our immigrant communities who are being [See County, A14]

County CEO gets payout after voters ax her job

By Rebecca Ellis

Fesia Davenport, Los Angeles County’s chief executive officer, received a \$2-million settlement this summer due to professional fallout from Measure G, a voter-approved ballot measure that will soon make her job obsolete, according to a letter she wrote to the county’s top lawyer.

Davenport wrote in the

July 8 letter, which was released by the county counsel through a public record request Tuesday, that she had been seeking \$2 million in damages for “reputational harm, embarrassment, and physical, emotional and mental distress caused by the Measure G.”

Under Measure G, which voters approved last November, the county chief executive, who manages the county government and

oversees its budget, will be elected by voters instead of appointed by the board. The elected county executive will be in place by 2028.

“Measure G is an unprecedented event, and has had, and will continue to have, an unprecedented impact on my professional reputation, health, career, income, and retirement,” Davenport wrote to county counsel Dawyn Harrison. “My hope is that after setting aside the

amount of my ask, that there can be a true focus on what the real issues are here — measure G has irrevocably changed my life, my professional career, economic outlook, and plans for the future.”

The existence of the \$2-million settlement, finalized in mid-August, was first reported Tuesday by LAist. It was unclear then what the settlement was for. [See Measure G, A14]

The secrets behind S. Korea’s cosmetics boom

By Max Kim

SEOUL — Jo Min-Su was working toward a computer science doctorate at one of South Korea’s best universities when he stumbled on his calling: building a better lip gloss.

The 30-year-old sat near his booth at Seoul Beauty Week, pulled out a stick of his brand — named Blup — and gave his upper lip a dewy pink glow-up.

“Nobody trusts a founder who doesn’t use his own product,” he said, smacking his lips.

Jo is one of the tens of thousands of entrepreneurs looking to strike it rich on the seemingly insatiable global demand for beauty products from South Korea.

Following in the slipstream of the superstars of

Thanks to K-pop nods and rapid product development, nation is now top makeup exporter to U.S.



Tina Hsu For The Times

BOTTLES of foundation made by the Korean manufacturer Cosmax for various brands are displayed.

K-pop, K-beauty has become a massive global business.

Los Angeles fans of South Korean imports flocked to KCON LA 2025 at the L.A. Convention Center in August. At the music and cultural festival, they saw top K-pop idols and lined up for K-beauty at skin care booths.

The three-day convention — which had more than 350 booths and attracted more than 100,000 people from around L.A. and the country — was sponsored by South Korean health and beauty giant Olive Young, which plans to open its first U.S. outlet in L.A. early next year.

The secret of K-beauty’s success has been the unlikely alliance of big manufacturers and small entrepreneurs to develop and [See Beauty, A11]

Gubernatorial hopeful Porter voices remorse

Democrat and UC law professor makes first public comments on viral video of her berating staff. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Yamamoto offers his own relief

Pitcher starts and ends Game 2 with mastery to hand Dodgers a 2-0 lead in NLCS, writes Dylan Hernández. **SPORTS, B10**

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Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

KFI show nixed as radio struggles

iHeart Media cancels O’Kelly’s AM program in latest round of cuts to industry. **BUSINESS, A9**

Hard road ahead for ex-hostages

They may be free, but recovery will take time, Israeli health officials say. **PERSPECTIVES, A2**

Weather
Sunshine.
L.A. Basin: 78/58. **B6**

